Paper 3 — Heritage of Islam

Cambridge Islamic Studies 9488 • October/November 2026 revision edition • 29 October 2026

Independent syllabus-mapped revision notes. Read alongside the official syllabus and the original papers. These notes cover a selected permitted case-study route, not every optional person/building in the syllabus. Predictions never remove examinable content.

1. Your course map and chosen examples

The governing source is the 2024–2026 syllabus, sections 3.1–3.4. This guide selects:

- 3.1 architecture: **Great Mosque of Damascus**. Spain remains necessary for interfaith legacy even though Damascus is the selected architectural case.
- 3.2 scientist: **Ibn al-Haytham, optics**. Supporting al-Khwarizmi and Ibn Sina examples provide flexibility for stimuli, not extra compulsory case studies.
- 3.3 two works: **Ibn Tufayl, Hayy ibn Yaqzan** and **al-Ghazali, The Incoherence of the Philosophers**.
- 3.4 two mosques: **Sultan Ahmed Mosque, Istanbul**, and **Great Mosque of Djenné, Mali**.

If your friends studied other permitted examples, keep their detailed classroom evidence and substitute it into the comparison frameworks. Do not abandon a well-studied case for an unfamiliar one merely because this guide uses it. The syllabus permits specified alternatives and some candidate choices; the selections here are not Cambridge's compulsory named choices.

Format: 90 minutes; 50 marks. Section A: choose Q1 or Q2. Section B: choose Q3 or Q4. Each question has (a) AO1 10 and (b) AO2 15. In Section A(a), use the actual figure AND your own knowledge. You cannot answer

both Section A questions and omit Section B.

Working timing: 5 minutes to choose and outline; about 40 minutes per question; 5 minutes to check. Within each question, about 15 minutes on (a), 23 on (b), 2 checking. These are practice targets, not official rules.

2. Section 3.1 — the Umayyads

Chronology and leadership

The Damascus-based Umayyad caliphate ruled from 661 to 750. The Umayyad emirate/caliphate in al-Andalus came later: do not collapse Syrian and Spanish histories into one reign. Mu'awiya I consolidated rule from Damascus; hereditary succession strengthened dynastic continuity but raises questions about consultation and political legitimacy. Abd al-Malik strengthened central authority, promoted Arabic administration and issued distinctive Islamic coinage. Al-Walid I sponsored major religious construction. Umar II is associated with reform and concern for religious justice. These rulers are not interchangeable.

Political leadership: organise administration, appoint governors, defend/expand territory, maintain communication and demonstrate authority. **Religious leadership:** sponsor mosques and Qur'anic learning, support worship, present the caliphate as guardian of the community. **Economic leadership:** support routes, currency and public works. The roles overlap: a mosque can serve worship, learning and the public display of state authority.

AO2 judgement: define what “successful” means before choosing a policy. Military expansion is not identical to justice; beautiful construction is not sufficient proof of personal piety. A strong answer considers effects on worshippers, converts, minority communities and the stability of the state.

Religious, educational and trade policies

Mosque patronage increased facilities for congregational prayer and teaching. Qur'anic inscriptions and public religious architecture made Islamic identity visible. Arabic administration and coinage could help integrate a large state and its economy. Trade and communication supported the circulation of people, ideas and goods; mosques were also places where learning could happen before later institutions developed.

Avoid claiming the Umayyads invented the Qur'an, compiled it for the first time, or created every later madrasa. The standardisation of the Qur'anic codex is associated with Uthman before this dynasty. Explain how an existing revelation was promoted and communicated.

Evaluate against Qur'an and Sunnah

Use criteria rather than praise/blame labels:

- **Justice and trust:** Qur'an 4:58 requires trusts to be returned and judgement with justice. Ask whether appointments and resources served the community.
- **Consultation:** Qur'an 42:38 values consultation. Hereditary succession can be criticised against this ideal, while defenders may argue continuity protected stability.
- **Religious provision:** mosques and education enabled communal obligations. Yet spending and prestige must be weighed against welfare.
- **Equality and moral conduct:** distinguish policy ideals from reported inequality, elite privilege or violent political conflict. Avoid treating every caliph, region and decade alike.

A defensible conclusion: Umayyad rule strengthened institutions through which Islam spread, but institutional success does not establish that every ruler followed every Qur'anic and Prophetic principle. Assess specific actions and acknowledge differing Muslim assessments of legitimacy.

Architecture case — Great Mosque of Damascus

The mosque was commissioned under al-Walid I in the early eighth century on a site with earlier Roman and Christian sacred uses. This makes it useful for **continuity and change**, not simply “Islam invented an entirely new architecture”. The prayer hall, courtyard and orientation support congregational worship; decoration and monumental scale communicate sacred significance and public authority. Its mosaics include vegetation and architectural landscapes rather than a portrayal of God.

Feature -> function -> interpretation: courtyard -> gathering and circulation -> shared community; prayer space oriented toward the qiblah -> united worship -> obedience and unity; vegetal mosaics -> beautification and contemplation -> possible allusion to abundance/Paradise. Distinguish a plausible interpretation from a documented universal meaning. Do not claim every tree mosaic certainly depicts Paradise.

Minaret: a tower associated with the call to prayer and the public visibility of Islam. The adhan proclaims God's greatness, the testimony of faith and invitation to prayer. Height has practical projection and symbolic visibility, but minarets are not required for a valid mosque. A minaret visible today may contain later rebuilding: do not date every visible element to al-Walid.

Source exercise: if the source shows arches, identify what you actually see and explain its relevance. Do not pretend an unseen inscription is legible. If the figure is unfamiliar, the task is still source use plus relevant knowledge, not guessing a famous name.

Continuity and change in art and culture

Change: reject idols as objects of worship; develop Qur'anic calligraphy and publicly Islamic inscriptions; adapt buildings to qiblah-oriented congregational prayer. Continuity: reuse columns, building techniques, mosaics and artistic expertise from earlier Mediterranean and regional traditions. Islam transformed purpose and meaning without abolishing every inherited material or technique.

Nuance: aniconism is especially important in religious settings and depictions of God are rejected. It is inaccurate to say no human or animal figure ever appeared anywhere in Muslim art: secular palaces and manuscripts provide counterexamples. Distinguish devotional prohibition, cultural practice and later artistic history.

Interfaith relations and Muslim Spain

Al-Andalus was a region of changing Muslim rule, not a single unbroken utopia. Jews and Christians could live as protected communities and contribute to intellectual and economic life. Arabic learning, translation and court service sometimes enabled cross-faith exchange. Córdoba and other centres became symbols of shared intellectual achievement.

Protection did not mean modern equal citizenship: legal status, taxes and access to power could differ. Relations also included coercion, conflict and persecution in particular periods. Maimonides' life illustrates both participation in the wider Arabic intellectual world and the limits of idealising every regime. Do not assign all later Almoravid/Almohad actions to the earlier Umayyads.

Legacy today: preserved buildings, study of philosophy and medicine, translation, and shared cultural memory can encourage interfaith understanding. Counterargument: contemporary civic equality rests on modern constitutions and law; historic coexistence does not prove direct causation. Strong conclusion: the past offers examples and warnings, not a ready-made modern constitution.

3. Section 3.2 — the Abbasids

Leadership and policy

The Abbasids displaced the Damascus Umayyads in 750. Al-Mansur founded Baghdad in 762; its location and administration helped make it a major political and commercial centre. Harun al-Rashid and al-Ma'mun are associated with learning and court patronage. Political authority, scholarly achievement and religious legitimacy must be assessed separately.

Religious life included Qur'anic scholarship, hadith, law and debate. Caliphs patronised scholars but could also pressure them. Al-Ma'mun's mihna, associated with enforcing a theological position about the Qur'an, is a concrete counterexample to the claim that state support for knowledge always meant unrestricted freedom. Distinguish a caliph's policy from the views of all Muslims.

Qur'an/Sunnah evaluation: ask whether education and welfare fulfilled communal responsibility, whether judgement was just, and whether coercion contradicted fair consultation and religious integrity. A ruler's promotion of a Qur'anic manuscript does not settle every question about political conduct.

Translation movement and openness

Arabic translation drew on Greek learning, often through Syriac intermediaries, as well as Persian and Indian traditions. Scholars of different religious backgrounds contributed: Hunayn ibn Ishaq, a Christian scholar, is a useful medical-translation example. Texts were copied, translated, compared and commented on. Paper and book culture aided preservation and circulation.

The House of Wisdom is an important symbol of Abbasid patronage, but avoid treating it as the only institution or imagining every scientist worked together in one modern research laboratory. Court patronage, private scholars, translators, physicians and libraries formed a broader intellectual environment.

Causal chain for AO1: patronage/resources -> access to texts and scholars -> Arabic translations -> criticism and further enquiry -> teaching and transmission. Explain links, not just list stages.

AO2: openness helped scholarship by enlarging the evidence base. However, stable institutions, demand for medicine/calculation, trade and individual talent also mattered. Openness was selective and varied under rulers; translation by itself is not the same as original discovery.

Scientific methods and comparison with today

Relevant methods include observation, measurement, mathematics, controlled enquiry, comparing explanations and recording results. Show the method through an example: a claim about light is tested against what happens in a controlled optical arrangement, rather than accepted solely because an earlier authority said it.

Similarities with modern science: evidence can challenge authority; mathematical models can explain observations; results can be checked. Differences: modern peer review, international specialisation, instrumentation and institutional funding are not identical to medieval patronage and manuscript circulation. Nor was every medieval scholar equally experimental. Scientific method developed through many cultures and periods.

Do not write: “The Abbasids were unquestionably the first scientists.” Instead: particular scholars made important advances in observation and experimentation, building on and revising earlier traditions.

Chosen scientist — Ibn al-Haytham

Ibn al-Haytham (c.965–c.1040), known in Latin as Alhazen, wrote the **Book of Optics (Kitab al-Manazir)**. He argued that vision occurs when light from objects enters the eye, rather than rays being emitted from the eye. His work combined mathematical reasoning and experiment, addressed reflection and refraction, and criticised inherited theories.

A darkened enclosure with a small opening helps demonstrate the behaviour of light. In an essay, explain why constraining light paths and observing their effects provides stronger evidence than relying on the prestige of a Greek authority. Do not invent a modern electronic experiment or claim he invented the modern camera in its complete form.

Important historical qualification: he belongs to the wider Islamic scientific heritage studied under the syllabus's Abbasid heading, but worked in **Fatimid Egypt**, not as a Baghdad Abbasid court scientist. Historical accuracy is more valuable than forcing every example under one patron. Britannica, Ibn al-Haytham.

Legacy: Arabic manuscripts and later Latin translation transmitted optical knowledge; later European scholars engaged with it. This supports an argument for continuity of knowledge across cultures. Calling one person the sole inventor of all scientific method oversimplifies that history.

Supporting breadth — medicine and mathematics

Ibn Sina (Avicenna): the Canon of Medicine organised medical learning and became influential in teaching. Its significance includes synthesis, classification and transmission, not the claim that every treatment is accepted today. For an anatomical manuscript stimulus, connect the visible organisation/diagram to systematic recording; do not infer a named author without evidence.

Al-Khwarizmi: work on algebra systematised methods for solving practical mathematical problems. Mathematical knowledge could serve inheritance calculations, commerce and administration. Avoid saying he invented all mathematics or every algebraic idea from nothing.

Hospitals and medical learning: training, observation of illness, organisation of care and preservation of texts are relevant. Do not turn the answer into a list of discoveries without explaining how they improved knowledge or practice.

Compare the dynasties and their legacies

Both used patronage, institutions and public symbols to consolidate authority. Both linked religious identity with state power and inherited earlier traditions. Umayyad examples are particularly useful for administration and monumental architecture; Abbasid examples for Arabic book culture, translation and scholarly patronage. These are emphases, not exclusive ownership: the Umayyads also supported learning and Abbasids also built and governed.

To judge “more Islamic”, set a criterion such as justice, worship provision or treatment of scholars, then compare specific rulers/policies under that same criterion. To judge “more influential”, consider duration, geographical reach, later transmission and continuing use. A building's survival and a book's translation are different kinds of legacy.

4. Section 3.3 — literature, philosophy and knowing God

Reason, revelation, observation and mysticism

Revelation: divine communication, especially the Qur'an; authoritative guidance concerning worship, moral duties and the unseen. **Reason:** drawing conclusions and testing consistency. **Observation:** attending to the natural world and human experience. **Mysticism:** cultivated inward devotion and spiritual experience, often associated with Sufi traditions. Do not treat them as necessarily mutually exclusive.

Qur'an 3:190–191 connects reflection on creation with remembrance of God. Qur'an 41:53 speaks of signs in horizons and selves. Such passages support reflection, but a natural observation does not by itself specify every ritual or settle every theological dispute. Interpretive assumptions matter.

Falsafah: philosophical enquiry drawing significantly on Greek traditions and developed in Arabic intellectual contexts. Shared concerns include logic, ethics, causality and metaphysics. Muslim thinkers debated how philosophical conclusions related to revelation, creation, divine knowledge and resurrection.

Greek comparison: continuity in logical methods and questions does not imply identity of all answers. Difference in religious commitments does not mean Muslims used an entirely different logic. Identify the shared method, then evaluate disagreement about premises and conclusions.

Work 1 — Ibn Tufayl, Hayy ibn Yaqzan

A philosophical narrative about an isolated individual's intellectual and spiritual development. Hayy's attention to living things and the natural world leads to increasingly abstract questions about life, causation and the source of existence. The work explores how unaided enquiry may reach truths also expressed through religious teaching.

Specific usable evidence: isolation makes social teaching absent at first; learning develops through experience and reflection; later contact with a

religious community raises the issue of how abstract truths can be communicated to people with different capacities and needs. Its narrative form itself is a method of communicating difficult beliefs.

AO2 strength: accessible story and natural enquiry can engage a reader not initially accepting scriptural authority. **Limit:** philosophical insight does not automatically translate into a workable common religious life; the story itself complicates the idea that every person will respond to an abstract argument. Do not summarise it as “reason makes revelation useless”. Britannica, Ibn Tufayl.

Work 2 — al-Ghazali, The Incoherence of the Philosophers

Al-Ghazali critically examines **twenty philosophical positions** associated with the philosophers. His target is the claim that certain metaphysical conclusions are demonstratively established. Important disputed issues include the eternity of the world, divine knowledge and bodily resurrection. His approach uses reasoning to challenge reasoning that claims more certainty than it can justify.

Specific usable evidence: the discussion of causation questions whether observed regular association proves a necessary causal connection independent of God's power. A familiar illustration is the association of fire and burning cotton. Explain the epistemic point: observation of repeated sequence is not automatically proof of metaphysical necessity.

Avoid two major errors: he did not reject all logic, and he did not simply “end science”. He accepted and used important philosophical tools while rejecting particular teachings. His relationship with philosophy and theology was complex. Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, al-Ghazali.

AO2 strength: protects the distinction between demonstrated knowledge and speculative claims, and defends revealed beliefs. **Limit/alternative:** critics may argue that too restrictive an approach discourages speculation or that philosophical interpretations can reconcile reason and revelation differently. Do not equate criticism of a metaphysical argument with rejection of every medical experiment.

Compare the two works

Hayy is especially useful for the potential of observation and reason to approach God; Incoherence for limits of claims to rational certainty. Both permit discussion of intellectual enquiry, rather than an easy “one accepts reason, the other bans it” contrast. Compare purpose, audience, method and what each can communicate today.

Da'wah today

Da'wah means inviting or explaining Islam, not coercing conversion. Qur'an 16:125 stresses wisdom and good engagement; 2:256 rejects compulsion in religion. Useful methods: clear translations and accessible literature, scholarly explanation, digital question-and-answer resources, open mosque events, respectful dialogue and ethical example/service.

Evaluate with criteria: accuracy, accessibility, audience, trust, consent and depth. Digital media have reach but can spread misinformation. Books allow sustained thought but require literacy and motivation. Personal example builds trust but may not explain doctrine precisely. A philosophical work can engage a reflective sceptic but overwhelm a beginner. The best conclusion usually specifies an audience and explains why a combination or particular method suits it.

Reasoning about creation and care for the environment

Creation can be understood as entrusted to human responsibility rather than owned without limits. Qur'an 7:31 warns against excess and 30:41 associates corruption on land/sea with human actions. Connect reasoning to a practical consequence: interdependence in nature can encourage conserving water and habitat.

Alternative view: duties can follow directly from revelation even where philosophical reflection is absent. Thus reasoning may motivate and explain stewardship without being its sole foundation. If asked about the relationship, do not write only a list of environmental projects.

5. Section 3.4 — architecture and design

A feature is not an argument until its meaning is explained

- **Geometry:** repeated order, symmetry and unity may encourage reflection on the order of creation and divine unity. Patterns themselves are created, not images of God or objects of worship.
- **Domes:** shelter and acoustic/spatial function; may suggest the heavens, unity and encompassing sacred space. They are historically variable, not a condition of Muslim worship.
- **Calligraphy:** words, especially Qur'anic text and divine names, communicate without portraying God. Explain the meaning of the particular words if legible; do not invent a verse from an unreadable image.
- **Gardens and water:** shade, flowing water and ordered abundance can evoke Qur'anic Paradise, e.g. 47:15. A garden is an analogy, not the actual unseen reality.
- **Mihrab/qiblah:** orient worship toward Makkah; unity in direction without worshipping the building.
- **Minbar:** platform associated with preaching; communal guidance and teaching.

God is not contained in a dome or physically represented by a pattern. Qur'an 42:11, that nothing is like God, supports caution about reducing the Creator to created forms.

Mosque 1 — Sultan Ahmed, Istanbul

An Ottoman imperial mosque commissioned by Ahmed I, built in the early seventeenth century (1609–1617). Learn the large central dome and cascading smaller domes, six slender minarets, courtyard and rich tile/calligraphic decoration. The interior is associated with blue Iznik tiles, hence “Blue Mosque”.

Use: scale and domed space can inspire awe; common prayer space and direction express unity; calligraphy teaches and reminds. **Critical angle:** imperial patronage also displays political prestige and wealth. A visitor's awe is not proof that costly architecture produces deeper faith than a plain mosque. Building/date reference.

Mosque 2 — Great Mosque of Djenné, Mali

The current building dates to **1907**, on a site with earlier mosque history. Its Sudano-Sahelian architecture uses earth/mud construction, buttresses, projecting wooden toron and a monumental façade with three towers. The toron assist maintenance. Annual replastering connects material preservation and community participation.

Use: local materials and climate-sensitive techniques show that Islamic worship need not take an Ottoman form. Collective care can embody stewardship and communal responsibility. Do not call it an Umayyad building, and do not assume it requires a large central dome to be Islamic. Smarthistory, Great Mosque of Djenné.

Direct comparison ready for an essay

Both facilitate collective worship, communicate communal identity and require ongoing care. Sultan Ahmed's stone/domed imperial architecture differs from Djenné's earthen Sahelian construction. The differences arise from climate, materials, patronage, craftsmanship and history, not different gods or necessarily different core beliefs.

Judgement: shared religious function does not require identical external design. Yet “anything goes” is also too broad: prayer orientation, appropriate worship space and avoidance of idolatry constrain design. Cultural diversity and religious continuity can coexist.

Preservation and modern design

Reasons to preserve: history, craftsmanship, identity, learning, stewardship and living religious use. Counterweights: cost, structural safety, accessibility, environmental impact and urgent social needs. Preservation should involve worshipping communities rather than turning every mosque into a museum.

New styles may serve growing communities, accessible design and environmental responsibility. Critics may fear commercial spectacle or loss of continuity. Judge a design by function, religious appropriateness and social benefit, not age alone. Djenné also shows that “preserve” can mean repeated renewal of material, not freezing every brick forever.

Books versus buildings

Books can specify doctrine and arguments; architecture is powerful for communal participation, atmosphere and non-verbal meaning. Books require reading and interpretation; buildings also need cultural interpretation and cannot alone teach every doctrine. A justified conclusion can prefer books for precision and buildings for embodied communal experience, then explain how the two reinforce one another.

6. Rapid AO1 evidence bank

Learn the following as explained evidence, not unsupported slogans:

1. Abd al-Malik: administration/coinage -> integration and visible Islamic authority.
2. Al-Walid I: Damascus mosque patronage -> worship and monumental state presence.
3. Umar II: reform example -> limits of treating all Umayyads identically.
4. Baghdad under al-Mansur -> administration, trade and intellectual networks.
5. Translation through Syriac and multi-faith scholars -> openness with concrete mechanisms.

6. Mihna -> tension between patronage, theology and coercion.
7. Ibn al-Haytham, Book of Optics -> experiment plus mathematical reasoning; Fatimid-context qualification.
8. Ibn Sina, Canon -> organisation/preservation of medicine, not “all modern cures”.
9. Hayy -> nature, reason and the problem of communicating abstract truths.
10. Incoherence -> twenty critiques and limits of demonstrative claims, not a ban on logic.
11. Sultan Ahmed versus Djenné -> unity of worship with diversity of form.
12. Qur'an 3:190–191 / 16:125 / 7:31 -> reflection / wise invitation / limits on excess.

7. Final syllabus checklist

Tick only when you can explain and evaluate, not merely recognise the word.

- [ ] 3.1 leadership, religion, education, trade and judgement against Qur'an/Sunnah.
- [ ] 3.1 minaret, selected Umayyad architecture, change/continuity, Spain's interfaith legacy.
- [ ] 3.2 leadership and Islamic evaluation; translation/openness; science/method and modern comparison.
- [ ] 3.2 one named scientist, preservation/transmission and legacies; comparison of dynasties.
- [ ] 3.3 reason/revelation/natural signs; Greek comparison; two actual works; mysticism and da'wah.
- [ ] 3.4 geometry/domes/Paradise/calligraphy/divine names; two mosques compared.

- [ ] 3.4 diversity, preservation, new styles, stewardship and books versus buildings.
- [ ] One timed Section A answer using an original figure and one timed Section B answer.

8. Assessment sources and cautions

The June 2026 Paper 3 mark scheme and official June 2024 examiner report inform the technique advice. Indicative schemes are not exhaustive fact-checked textbooks: some historical generalisations require qualification. Qur'anic references above are paraphrased meanings, not a claim to reproduce one exact English translation. In the examination use accurately learnt wording or clearly identified paraphrase.